Core game design - Wizard Yan's Diary: The Remembrance Alchemy

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Project overview

Working title: Wizard Yan's Diary: The Remembrance Alchemy (WYDRA)
Genre: Narrative alchemy adventure, cozy, simulation, puzzle
Perspective: Third person, 2D, pixel
Player character: Rob, an otter spirit familiar
Setting: Fantasy inspired by 18th-century Poland and Sarmatian culture
Primary progression: Knowledge, memories, relationships, alchemical understanding

High Concept

A young alchemist accidentally summons the spirit of a long-dead otter. Together they study alchemy in an isolated tower, hoping to recreate the otter's physical form. As the spirit recovers fragmented memories of his former life, however, both discover that remembering who he was may be different from deciding who he is now.

Core fantasy

Be an otter. Explore a strange alchemical world. Learn how things work. Build a relationship with a young alchemist. Recover a forgotten life. Decide what it means to come back.

Unique selling points

The player is controlling the spirit of a dead creature to be resurrected.

This deconstructs the usual resurrection tropes and allows the player to explore the philosophical dilemma of "old life" vs "new life", leaving it up to player whether they want to come back in the end.

Alchemy is learned through experimentation and understanding, not recipes.

The first thing the player learns about alchemy is that the ingredients don't matter, but their properties do. This deconstructs the usual crafting system flow: find a recipe, gather ingredients, craft an item.

Player's relationship with Yan keeps track of what was said and had happened.

The characters remember player's choices and those memories shape how they understand each other.

Design pillars

Curiosity and experimentation

The player progresses by understanding systems and experimenting with the world around them. They should be encouraged to remain curious and draw conclusions based on both successful and failed experiments. The player should feel like they are in a safe space.

Discovery should precede explanation

Rather than relying on exposition, tutorial and checklists, I want the player to discover the world through experience, inference and understanding.

Systems should express the story

Alchemy, memory, exploration, relationships, and the workshop should reinforce the same themes.

The world remembers

Actions should have consequences that can return later. Characters don't simply reset after conversations but can reference a hurtful or a kind line later in the story.

Past and present should coexist

Rob's historical life matters, but the game shouldn't imply that his old life is automatically more important than his new one.

Core player experience

The player explores the world as Rob, a spirit of a legendary otter Robak, summoned by alchemist Yan to help him learn alchemy. The player encounters new materials and memories, conducts experiments with alchemy alongside Yan, and gradually develops their understanding of alchemy, Rob's story, and their relationship with Yan.

Core gameplay structure – learning cycles

The game is structured around a series of player-driven learning cycles. The player can explore, experiment, investigate memories, interact with Yan, place objects around the tower, and pursue discoveries in different orders. These activities gradually expand the list of available ingredients, number of alchemical stations, improve the workshop and build the player's understanding of alchemy and Rob's own history. Each cycle converges on an alchemy examination, where the game tests whether the player understands the principles that they have encountered.

Player activities

Exploration

The player can go on a trip to visit a nearby town, forest and lake to acquire new ingredients and other points of interest. Exploration is also the primary way of to uncover memories of Robak's past.

Memories can surface spontaneously in response to environmental cues. Visiting the lake, for example, may trigger a recollection of travelling with Jan, while hearing a bell tower may remind Rob of Robak's bell collar. Other discoveries require the player to investigate points of interest and actively uncover clues.

Exploration should feel like a peaceful adventure. The player walks through the forest, listens to the sounds of nature, admires the scenery, and discovers things at their own pace. The world is an atmospheric space for reflection and discovery.

Alchemy experimentation

Alchemy is a spatial reasoning system. Ingredients are charged with elemental energy, which moves the mixture through elemental space like vectors on a plane. The ingredients themselves don't matter, the overall elemental composition of the mixture does.

The alchemy system is supported by a dedicated design document (Github) and a playable Godot prototype (Github), developed and refined through playtesting and iteration.





Playable Godot prototype, iterations 0.1.0 to 0.4.0

Memory investigation

Memories encompass both Robak's past experiences and new experiences Rob creates with Yan. Some provide concrete evidence about the past, while others offer incomplete clues or subjective impressions. Memories of Rob's life with Yan provide a different perspective, revealing how their relationship develops and allowing the player to compare Rob's present experiences with Robak's past.

Example: Rob discovers a memory suggesting that Jan allowed the king to take Robak away, leading Rob to resent him. By investigation another memory, Rob learns that the king had threatened Jan and that Jan had tried his best to protect Robak. This new context challenges Rob's initial interpretation of Jan's actions as betrayal and abandonment.

Interacting with Yan

Dialogue allows Rob to discuss a variety of topics with Yan, including alchemy, philosophy, and their evolving relationship. Conversations also offer moments of casual exchange, allowing the player to learn more about Yan and their life together.

Yan helps guide the player's exploration and progression. He can point out new locations to explore, provide blueprints for tower rooms that encourage the player to decorate and organize their home, and offer clues about alchemical examinations to support the player's learning.

Yan is an important partner in investigating Rob's memories. The player can bring up specific memories to question contradictions, reconsider past events, or clarify Yan's remarks. These discussions can provide new context and challenge Rob's existing interpretations, helping the player piece together Robak's past and reflect on Rob's identity.

Conversations serve both as a source of knowledge and as a way to develop Rob and Yan's relationship.

Placing objects around the tower

The tower becomes Rob's new home. To encourage attachment to this place, the player can decorate it with objects they have crafted, such as the first potion they brewed, a poster, a potted plant or an otter bed.

The tower consists of multiple floors, each functioning as a separate room. Players can freely place, pick up, and rearrange to personalize the space. Objects belonging to Yan cannot be moved, and individual objects may have placement restrictions, such as allowing only one otter bed in the entire tower.

Optional blueprints provided by Yan encourage players to furnish rooms for specific purposes, such as kitchen or bedroom. Completing a blueprint by meeting its furnishing requirements unlocks some cosmetic rewards; for example, a completing a music room unlocks soundtrack variant.

Alchemical examination

The alchemical examination is an ongoing activity available throughout each learning cycle. It challenges the player to demonstrate their understanding by completing practical tasks, such as crafting a specific object, or answering conceptual questions about alchemical rule.

The player attempt the examination at any time and return to unanswered questions as they acquire more knowledge. Passing the examination is the requirement for advancing to the next learning cycle, unlocking new stages for exploration, alchemical possibilities, and narrative developments.

Example: a learning cycle

At the start of a learning cycle, the player examines the first. It asks them to create an object with a specific elemental composition.

The player lacks the necessary ingredients. With a hint from Yan, they explore a nearby forest, discover a new ingredient, and use it to craft the required object.

The next question asks the player to explain an alchemical rule. They present a memory as their answer, but the examination rejects it. After discussing the rule with Yan and experimenting, they arrive at a different explanation and revise their interpretation of the memory. The examination accepts the revised answer.

Through the examination, the player discovers what they need to learn next. They pursue practical knowledge through exploration and experimentation, and conceptual knowledge through memories and dialogue. The player chooses how to approach each challenge, while passing the examination gates progression to the next learning cycle.

Objects and Inventory

The player has one inventory organized into tabs for different object types:

- **Ingredients** are unlocked through exploration and alchemical discoveries. Once unlocked, they can be used indefinitely without being consumed. This allows players to freely experiment without resource scarcity discouraging experimentation.
- **Placeable objects** can be crafted through alchemy and placed around the tower. Each object has placement restrictions.
- **Memories** are fragments of Robak's past, events experienced as Rob, and belief about the world and himself. Players can investigate and reinterpret them through dialogue with Yan and use them to answer questions in alchemical examinations.
- **Stations** are functional instruments used for processing ingredients, which alter their properties. They expand the player's alchemical capabilities and are unlocked through progression.

The available tabs serve different functions depending on the player's current activity:

- **Exploration**: The inventory serves as a reference catalogue for discovered ingredients, memories, placeable objects, and stations.
- **Alchemy**: The ingredients and stations tabs serve as selection menus for experimentation.
- **Dialogue with Yan**: The memories tab allows the player to investigate memories and discuss them with Yan.
- **Tower decoration**: The placeable objects tab allows the player to select objects to place or relocate around the tower.
- **Alchemical examination**: All tabs are available to help the player answer examination questions,

This context-sensitive approach gives the inventory multiple purposes while maintaining a single, consistent interface.

Progression

Player's knowledge

Over the course of the game the player will have to learn the mechanics behind alchemy – elemental properties of ingredients, how they change through various stations, the rules of each station, how recipes work.

Rob's and Robak's memories

As the game progresses, Rob acquires more memories about his past life (Robak), which slowly fill in the gaps in understanding his story and what it would mean to be resurrected.

At the same time, he creates new memories through interacting with Yan and exploring the world. Some memories are blurry because of the resurrection spell, it's up to player to construct their own version of the story.

Relationship progression

At the start of the game, Yan believes that Rob is just a familiar spirit. Soon they develop a student/teacher relationship, which blooms into friendship. As they both learn the story of Robak and Jan, Yan realizes that Rob has lived a life that was abruptly taken away from him. He questions whether it is right to resurrect Robak, and what their friendship means.

World progression

The game narrative is reflected in the passing of seasons. Poland experiences six distinct natural seasons: early spring, true spring, summer, golden autumn, deep autumn and winter. The game starts in golden autumn and ends next golden autumn. Passing an alchemical examination advances the season to the next one. It also unlocks new locations with memories and ingredients.

Alchemy progression

When the game starts, the player can acquire only a handful of ingredients. The only available alchemical station is the cauldron. Through exploration and alchemy, they will unlock more potent ingredients. Passing an examination unlocks new alchemical stations, like mortar and alembic, which can be used to further process ingredients.

Systems relationships

Exploration unlocks new ingredients for **alchemy** and memories for **investigation**.

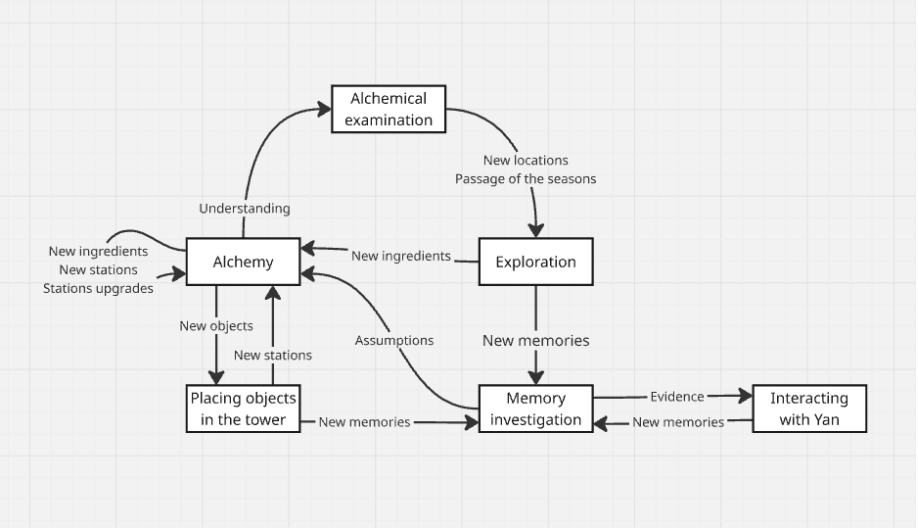
Alchemy provides a **self-feeding** loop for discovering new ingredients and upgrading stations. It also raises understanding of the alchemy systems for **examination**. Moreover, objects crafted in alchemy can be **placed in the tower**.

Memory investigation is the primary system for learning the backstory of Rob. Some assumptions about **alchemy** are in the form of memories. Memories can also be used while **interacting with Yan**.

Interacting with Yan creates **memories** about Rob's current and previous life as well as **alchemy**.

Placing objects in the tower unlocks some new stations for **alchemy**. Some objects can be used to create new **memories** about Rob's current life, i.e. placing a pile of stones, a bell collar, otter's bed.

Passing an **alchemical examination** unlocks more locations for **exploration**, and in some cases new stations for **alchemy**. It is also the only way to progress the story.



Narrative

The story is structured in seven acts, themed around the six seasons of Poland. The game starts and ends in the golden autumn, giving it a circular structure. The narrative is covered in a separate design document (GitHub).

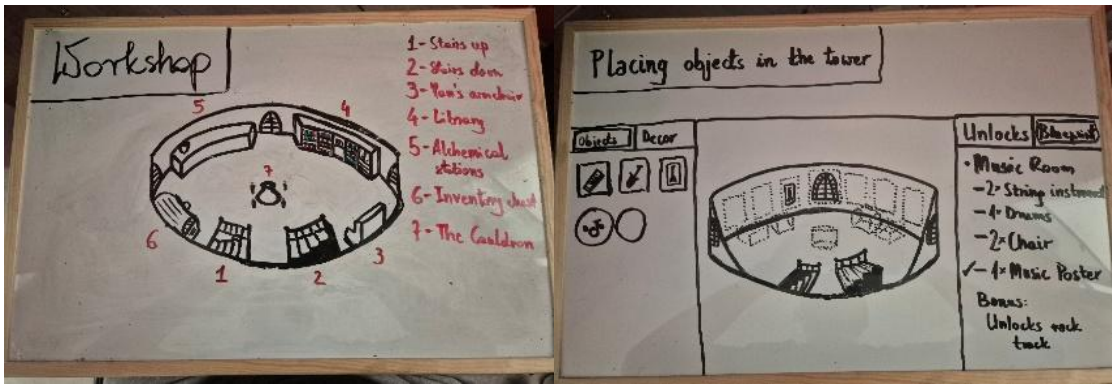
Here is a short synopsis:

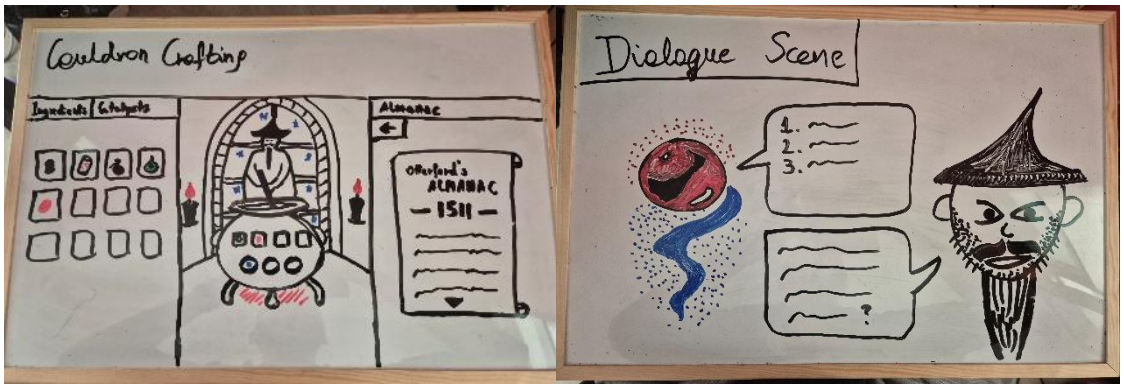
In the 17th century, Jan loses his beloved pet otter Robak. Overcame by grief, he builds a tower and dedicates his life to study of alchemy, searching for a way to resurrect Robak. His research in incomplete, but he records his findings in a book “The Remembrance Alchemy”. A century later Yan, a young alchemist, moves into Jan’s tower. He finds the book and decides to finish Jan’s research. He summons a familiar spirit to aid him and names him Rob. Rob experiences memories of Robak in response to various events, slowly uncovering Robak’s story of companionship, captivity and tragic death. Meanwhile, Yan conducts the research and battles his perfectionism. At the end of each season, the duo take on alchemical examination, which aims to resolve unanswered questions from the book. When the research is completed, it is revealed that there is no resurrection. Instead, a portal to memory of Robak’s death opens. Rob must decide if he’s Robak or Rob. There are four endings:

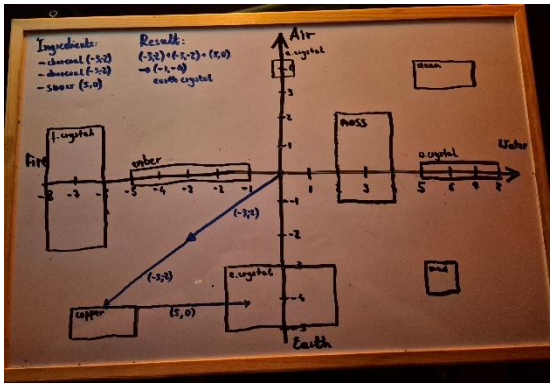
- Rob decides he’s Robak, enters the portal and dies. This restarts the story.
- Rob decides he’s Rob and stays with Yan.

- Rob decides he's both Rob and Robak, Yan follows him to the memory and saves him.
- Rob decides he's neither Robak nor Rob, and leaves Yan.

Concept art







Alchemy map

Open design questions

1. How much of the game is exploration vs experimentation?
2. How much should alchemy progression be tied to other systems?
3. Which form of alchemical examination would be the most coherent with the story (knowledge test, live experimentation, presenting memories)?
4. How much freedom should the player have in memory investigation?